



ON THE WRITE LINE

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PLAYING THE RANJI TROPHY AT THE START OF THE SEASON IN OCTOBER IS A PRUDENT CALL

Playing the Ranji matches with a **scheduled start time** of 09.30 am is pretty impossible in North India from mid-December to mid-January.

India defeated England by five wickets in the fourth Test in Ranchi to win the five-match series 3-1, with the final Test scheduled to be held in Dharamsala from March 7. What's been impressive is the way some of the younger guys have put their hands up, and while there will be sterner examinations, especially overseas, what has been heartwarming is the temperament.

It's always temperament that separates the men from the boys, and these boys are well on the way to becoming men if they stay true to the work ethic that has gotten them international status and don't get carried away with sundry things that invariably crop up when a bit of name and fame comes their way.

What would be even greater is for them to realise and remember that all that will come about only because of Indian cricket, and to never forget that and take Indian cricket for granted. The fact that the BCCI Secretary, Jay Shah, had to send a stern reminder to some of

the players to participate in domestic cricket does indicate that maybe some players think that they can do without Indian cricket.

At the start of the IPL in 2008, the BCCI made it mandatory for domestic players to play a minimum number of Ranji matches if they were to get a NOC to play in the money-spinning IPL.

There was also a cap of Rs 20 lakh on the fees of those who hadn't played for the country. Then, when an uncapped overseas player went for more than half a million dollars, the question was raised as to why the Indian uncapped player should be restricted to 20 lakhs while the overseas player was not similarly restricted. Now, with an uncapped player fetching crores, there's understandably more keenness in not getting injured playing some other domestic tournament and thus missing out on a life-changing opportunity in the IPL.

Perhaps the best way to avoid this would be